

Sengis

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Macroscelidea
FAMILIES	1 (Macroscelididae)
SPECIES	15

The long, pointed snout, which is flexible and highly sensitive, gives sengis their alternative name of elephant-shrew. They have keen senses of hearing and vision, and long, powerful back legs for running swiftly around their territory. Sengis are found only in Africa, where their habitat ranges from stony ground and grassland to forest undergrowth. They forage mostly by day, feeding on invertebrates.

BURROWS AND TRAILS

Sengis are strictly terrestrial and live in a variety of habitats. The Karoo rock sengi (right) favors rocky areas where it will either dig its own burrow or occupy one that has been abandoned. It maintains a system of trails that lead from the burrow to feeding areas. This behavioral pattern is seen in several sengi species.



Elephantulus rufescens

Rufous sengi



Length 4¼–5 in (12–12.5 cm)
Tail 5–5½ in (13–13.5 cm)
Weight 1¼–2½ oz (50–60 g)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Least concern



Gray to brown with white underparts, this species has a white eye-ring with a dark patch on the outer edge. In addition to small creatures, it eats soft fruit, seeds, and buds. The 1–2 young are born after a gestation period of 60



days. A male–female pair defend their territory by drumming their back feet and chasing away the intruder. The male chases out other males, and the female other females.

Rhynchocyon chrysopygus

Golden-rumped sengi



Length 10½–11½ in (27–29 cm)
Tail 9–10 in (23–26 cm)
Weight 1¼ lb (525–550 g)
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Endangered



This colorful species has hairless black feet, legs, and ears, a mainly black, white-tipped, sparsely furred tail, russet-colored head and body, and a golden patch on the rump. Its diet consists of small invertebrates, such



as worms, insects, and centipedes. When threatened, this sengi slaps its tail on the leaves to warn others, then bounds away at great speed, often with a stiff-legged leap to demonstrate its vigor.

Elephantulus pilicaudus

Karoo rock sengi



Length 4–5½ in (10.5–14.5 cm)
Tail 4¼–6 in (11.2–15.1 cm)
Weight 1¼–1¾ oz (38–52 g)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Data deficient



This species was distinguished from the closely allied Cape sengi in 2008. It is restricted to the Nama-Karoo region of South Africa, and is distinguished by a tufted tail and subtle features of its body pattern, such as mottled underparts and buff-colored cheeks. It lives among boulders in scattered rocky habitats on mountain slopes above 4,265 ft (1,300 m)—a landscape unsuitable for agriculture or development. However, it is known from only 17 specimens, so probably has low population density.



Rhynchocyon udzungwensis

Gray-faced sengi



Length 11¼–12½ in (30–32 cm)
Tail 9½–10 in (24–26 cm)
Weight 1½ lb (710 g)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Vulnerable



Initially found in 2005 by camera-trapping, this animal is one of many new species discovered in the exceptionally diverse communities of Udzungwa



Mountain in Tanzania. It is the largest member of a genus of “giant sengis” and is distinguished by a gray face, yellow chest, orange sides, maroon back, and black thighs. It is known from only 2 populations, covering a combined forest area of scarcely 115 square miles (300 square km)—with around 50–80 individuals per square km. This makes this species vulnerable to natural disasters—such as fires (whether natural or human-caused). Global warming could reduce its cool montane habitat too. Like related species, it builds a nest consisting of a cup in soil lined with dry leaves, topped with a cryptic dome of leaf litter.

Rhynchocyon petersi

Black and rufous sengi



Length 9–12½ in (23–32 cm)
Tail 7½–10½ in (19–27 cm)
Weight c. 7⁄8 lb (400 g)
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Vulnerable



One of four brightly colored “giant” or “checkered” sengis, this species has an orange head and upper body, graduating through red on the back to black on the rump—and with an orange-brown tail. It occurs in southeastern Kenya and northeastern Tanzania, including Zanzibar Island. “Giant” sengis of the genus Rhynchocyon are nervous, twitchy forest-dwelling animals and do not bound as much as other members of the family.

